The 11th Degree – Elu of the Twelve or Prince Ameth



The apron is white, lined, edged and fringed with black and the flap is black. In the middle is an embroidered flaming heart.

The cordon is a broad black watered ribbon, worn from right to left. Over the flaming heart on the cordon are painted or embroidered the words *Vincere aut Mori*; literally, “Either Conquer or Die.”

The flaming heart upon the apron and cordon are symbols of that zeal and devotedness that ought to animate all Masons and of those noble and heroic souls that have in all ages suffered and sacrificed themselves for their fellows or their country. The motto is a solemn pledge that one would rather die than betray the cause of the people or be overcome through his own fault.

The jewel is a sword of gold, suspended from the cordon, and represents truth. The Elu of the Twelve have been given the title of Prince *Ameth* or Prince of

Truth, for “Truth is sharper than any two–edged sword” (Hebrews 4:12).

DUTIES

Be earnest, true and reliable. Be the champion of the people.

LESSONS

Life is a school. Masonry is work.

FOR REFLECTION

Is Masonry’s work ever completed?

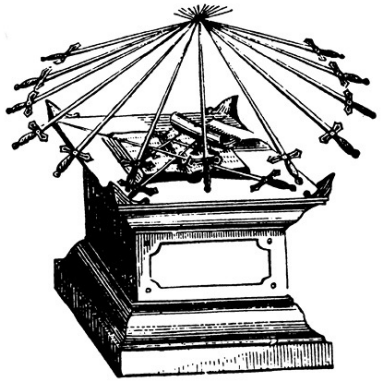
IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Flaming heart, the twelve Elus, swords with points touching in a circle.

In each degree Albert Pike cleverly provides hints of future lessons and reminders of past lessons. Often too, he attributes a special meaning to a specific symbol or character mentioned in a degree. Here we are informed that the previous Elu Degrees (9th and 10th) symbolize an independent legislature, an indispensable feature of free government. The nine Elus represent the upper house; they are fewer in number, more mature in wisdom and elected for longer terms than those of the lower house, symbolized by the Elu of the Fifteen. This degree should remind us of another institution necessary for true liberty– the trial by a jury of twelve men whose unanimous verdict is necessary to convict someone of a crime.

CEREMONY

The lodge represents the Audience Chamber of King Solomon. The hangings are black sprinkled with red and silver tears; the altar is covered with black strewn only with silver tears. Twelve candles light the lodge, three arranged to form a triangle in each quarter of the room, the East, West, North and South. This may be interpreted as a symbolic representation of the presence of Deity everywhere or as a statement that the work of Masonry, the practice of virtue, and the performance of duties required of an Elu of the Twelve should be evident in all spheres of a Mason’s life.



Prior to the reception, the brethren assemble around the altar, swords drawn and placed at a forty–five degree angle with the points touching. In this configuration, the brethren renew their pledge as Elus of the Twelve. This action is just one of the many examples in all the degrees of the repetitive nature of the lessons; you will recall this is also seen in the 10th Degree.

As the drama begins, Zabud, a judge in Israel, is about to sit in judgment upon the assassins of our Grand Master Hiram Abif. Benaias enters with the assassins, and Zabud invites the Elus to assemble as witnesses. The assassins confess to their crime and imprecate themselves with a peculiar punishment. The are judged guilty under the law of Moses and accordingly punished.

King Solomon inquires if the demands of justice have been satisfied. He is told that the assassins have been executed. Solomon declares that from this day forward the Master Hiram is the symbol inflexible fidelity and the assassins are the symbols of ignorance, ambition and fanaticism.

Solomon is then told that many complaints have been received from the people in his kingdom. Those charged with collection of the tribute are practicing extortion and collecting more from the people than is put into the treasury. King Hiram of Tyre counsels Solomon to appoint his own officers to collect the revenues and compensate them fairly.

King Solomon selects by lot twelve of the fifteen Elus to be governors in Israel. They are charged with collection of the revenues and given supreme control in their province. The candidate represents Ben–Dekar who is among the twelve chosen. The twelve are advanced to the rank and dignity of Princes

Ameth. Ameth is a Hebrew word meaning: truth, fidelity, firmness and constancy in keeping one's promises. His duties are to be earnest, true and reliable. A Prince Ameth is the advocate and champion of the people. An Elu of the Twelve must protect the people against illegal impositions. He is to do that which is right so that those who rely upon him will not be disappointed.

LECTURE

The lecture for this degree is well focused on the duties presented in the ceremony. Fulfilling the duties of a Prince Ameth—be true, earnest, reliable, sincere, and protect the people—requires the Mason to view himself and the whole of the human race as one great family; thus the duties of a Prince Ameth extend from himself to his family, his lodge, his brothers, his neighbors, his country and the world. The lecture assumes the broadest interpretation of these duties and in so doing provides us with a review of the duties and lessons of previous degrees; for example, "death" from the 5th Degree and "fidelity" from the 4th. Pike emphasizes that all of life is a school; this lesson is appropriate here because to be earnest and true requires education and enlightenment on the meaning of life, the Deity and human nature. Finally, we learn that Masonry's special charge is to protect the people and is therefore work.

Be a Prince Ameth:

You are to be true unto all men. You are to be frank and sincere in all things. You are to be earnest in doing whatever it is your duty to do. And no man must repent that he has relied upon your resolve, your profession, or your word (p. 176).

Truth, a Mason is early told, is a Divine attribute and the foundation of every virtue; and frankness, reliability, sincerity, straightforwardness, plain–dealing, are but different modes in which Truth develops itself (p. 184).

Education and Enlightenment:

Unfortunately, every age presents its own special problem, most difficult and often impossible to solve; and that which this age offers, and forces upon the

consideration of all thinking men, is this—how, in a populous and wealthy country, blessed with free institutions and a constitutional government, are the great masses of the manual-labor class to be enabled to have steady work at fair wages, to be kept from starvation, and their children from vice and debauchery, and to be furnished with that degree, not of mere reading and writing, but of knowledge, that shall fit them intelligently to do the duties and exercise the privileges of freemen; even to be intrusted with the dangerous right of suffrage? (p. 178).

For it is true now, as it always was and always will be, that to be free is the same thing as to be pious, to be wise, to be temperate and just, to be frugal and abstinent, and to be magnanimous and brave; and to be the opposite of all these is the same as to be a slave (p. 180).

Life is a school. The world is neither prison nor penitentiary, nor a palace of ease, nor an amphitheatre for games and spectacles; but a place of instruction, and discipline. Life is given for moral and spiritual training; and the entire course of the great school of life is an education for virtue, happiness, and a future existence. The periods of Life are its terms; all human conditions, its forms; all human employments, its lessons. Families are the primary departments of this moral education; the various circles of society, its advanced stages; Kingdoms and Republics, its universities (p. 182).

The poor man also is at school. Let him take care that he learn, rather than complain. Let him hold to his integrity, his candor, and his kindness of heart. Let him beware of envy, and of bondage, and keep his self–respect. The body's toil is nothing. Let him beware of the mind's drudgery and degradation. While he betters his condition if he can, let him be more anxious to better his soul. Let him be willing, while poor, and even if always poor, to learn poverty's great lessons, fortitude, cheerfulness, contentment, and implicit confidence in God's Providence (pp. 182–183).

...the school of life is carefully adjusted, in all its arrangements and tasks, to man's powers and passions. There is no extravagance in its teachings; nor is anything done for the sake of present effect. The whole course of human life is a conflict with difficulties; and, if rightly conducted, a progress in improvement. It is never too late for man to learn (p. 184).

Protect the People:

Masonry will do all in its power, by direct exertion and cooperation, to improve and inform as well as to protect the people; to better their physical condition, relieve their miseries, supply their wants, and minister to their necessities. Let every Mason in this good work do all that may be in his power (p. 180).

It is because Masonry imposes upon us these duties that it is properly and significantly styled work; and he who imagines that he becomes a Mason by merely taking the first two or three Degrees, and that he may, having leisurely stepped upon that small elevation, thenceforward worthily wear the honors of Masonry, without labor or exertion, or self–denial or sacrifice, and that there is nothing to be done in Masonry, is strangely deceived (p. 185).